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# Culturally Divergent Responses to Mortality Salience

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## Abstract

Two experiments compared the effects of death thoughts, or mortality salience, on European and Asian Americans. Research on terror management theory has demonstrated that in Western cultural groups, individuals typically employ self-protective strategies in the face of death-related thoughts. Given fundamental East-West differences in self-construal (i.e., the independent vs. interdependent self), we predicted that members of Eastern cultural groups would affirm other people, rather than defend and affirm the self, after encountering conditions of mortality salience. We primed European Americans and Asian Americans with either a death or a control prime and examined the effect of this manipulation on attitudes about a person who violates cultural norms (Study 1) and on attributions about the plight of an innocent victim (Study 2). Mortality salience promoted culturally divergent responses, leading European Americans to defend the self and Asian Americans to defend other people.

## Keywords

mortality, culture, terror management, the self

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Over the past two decades, terror management theory (TMT) researchers have accrued extensive evidence demonstrating how individuals respond to the problem of the threat of death (Rosenblatt, Greenberg, Solomon, Pyszczynski, & Lyon, 1989). Given the basic premise that death awareness, or *mortality salience*, can be paralyzing, TMT posits that humans have evolved psychological strategies—such as self-esteem (Pyszczynski, Greenberg, Solomon, Arndt, & Schimel, 2004)—as defenses against the existential angst that thinking about their own mortality elicits. The bulk of TMT research has focused on positive self-evaluations as buffers against death-related anxiety. Studies indicate that during periods of mortality salience, individuals increase their adherence to cultural values and worldviews in order to contribute to or play a part in something more enduring than the self (e.g., Gailliot, Stillman, Schmeichel, Plant, & Maner, 2008; Maheswaran & Agrawal, 2004).

Although terror management processes may be universal in the sense that they are designed to help people cope with mortality salience, the specific techniques used to cope should nevertheless be culturally contingent. Though this has long been acknowledged by TMT theorists (Greenberg et al., 1990), few empirical studies have explored the nature and divergence of such coping processes across cultures.

The vast majority of TMT studies have focused on European Americans and typically have found that individuals employ defensive strategies to protect the self in the face of mortality salience (for a review, see Greenberg, Solomon, & Pyszczynski, 1997). Such self-protective strategies include derogating people who are dissimilar to the self (including out-groups) and promoting people who are similar to the self (including in-groups; e.g., Rosenblatt et al., 1989), as well as psychologically distancing the self from innocent victims (Hirschberger, 2006; Hirschberger, Florian, & Mikulincer, 2005). These strategies involve positively evaluating entities that are similar to the self and devaluing those that are different. These findings are consistent with long-standing Western ideas of the self as an individualistic, independent entity (e.g., Markus & Kitayama, 1991). Thus, death is viewed primarily as a threat to the self, and efforts to cope with death involve restoring the self.

In Eastern cultures, the self is viewed not as an independent entity, but as an entity inherently tied to the collective. Hence, we posit that mortality salience should have a different effect on Asian Americans than on European Americans. Under interdependent self-construal (Markus & Kitayama, 1991), the East Asian self is one whose feelings, needs, and thoughts are tied to those of other people (Chentsova-Dutton & Tsai, 2010). Consequently, the threat of death should derive not from the

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disintegration of the self, but from the disintegration of social ties. Thus, among Asian Americans, mortality salience should spur efforts to restore or affirm others, rather than the self.[1]

We hypothesized that mortality salience should produce divergent cultural responses. Given prior research, we predicted that European Americans would respond to mortality salience with self-protective strategies aimed at affirming the self and derogating dissimilar others. In contrast, we predicted that Asian Americans would respond to mortality salience by using strategies aimed at affirming other people and by becoming less derogating of those dissimilar to the self. In the face of death, Asian Americans should seek to bolster the connectedness between individuals. The importance of the self should decrease, whereas the importance of other people should increase.

To test this hypothesis, we conducted two studies using different TMT paradigms. In Study 1, we presented European Americans and Asian Americans with either a mortality-salience or a control prime and then measured participants' attitudes toward a person who was dissimilar to themselves—a prostitute. Past research has shown that in the face of mortality salience, European Americans tend to derogate dissimilar others, as such derogation indirectly bolsters the self by affirming the validity of one's cultural worldview (Rosenblatt et al., 1989). We predicted that whereas European Americans would opt for this strategy under mortality-salience conditions, Asian Americans would actually embrace the dissimilar other to affirm their interdependence and to bolster the collective.

At first glance, it is counterintuitive that embracing a nonnormative individual would be a form of promoting the collective. Traditionally, Asians' collectivism applies primarily to in-group members (Markus & Kitayama, 1991), and prostitutes stand, at best, as "fringe" in-group members and, at worst, as out-group members. Nevertheless, we believe that the use of this kind of dissimilar other is a particularly stringent test of our hypothesis. Given that death threat tends to magnify—and often distort—culturally bound attitudinal and behavioral patterns, our hypothesis is not so extraordinary.

For example, under normal (i.e., no threat) conditions, European Americans tend to endorse egalitarian values and are relatively socially liberal (e.g., Chia, Moore, Lam, & Chuang, 1994; Ross, 1997; Wang, 1998). However, under mortality-salience conditions, European Americans become highly nationalistic and derogating of dissimilar others, exhibiting a distorted magnification of the general Western tendency to enhance the self and all things related to the self. In contrast, under normal conditions, Asian Americans tend to be relatively socially conservative. However, we expected that under mortality-salience conditions, they would magnify the general Asian tendency toward collectivism and interdependence to the point of embracing nonnormative individuals, who would typically be derogated under no-threat conditions.

In Study 2, we again presented European Americans and Asian Americans with the mortality-salience or control prime; we subsequently measured their psychological distancing from an innocent victim. Existing research shows that blaming innocent victims for their plight establishes a sense of psychological distance from them (Hirschberger, 2006; Hirschberger et al., 2005). Thus, assignment of blame is a form of self-protection against death threat, as it denies one's own vulnerability; such protection is functionally achieved when one rejects a severely injured victim (Goldenberg, Pyszczynski, Greenberg, & Solomon, 2000; Greenberg, Arndt, Simon, Pyszczynski, & Solomon, 2000). We predicted that whereas European Americans would respond to mortality salience with increased psychological distancing (i.e., to protect the self), Asian Americans would respond with decreased psychological distancing (i.e., to affirm the interdependence between individuals).

## Study 1

### *Participants*

Twenty-two European Americans (7 men and 15 women; average age = 20.50 years) and 20 Asian Americans (8 men and 12 women of Chinese, Japanese, or Korean descent; average age = 22.09 years) participated in this study. Of the 20 Asian Americans, 10 were first generation (i.e., born abroad); the remainder were second generation (i.e., born in the United States to parents born abroad).

### *Measures and procedure*

Following the typical TMT paradigm, we asked participants to write down their thoughts regarding either their own death (mortality-salience condition) or dental pain (control condition). Next, using the procedures described by Cox et al. (2009), participants completed the Positive and Negative Affect Schedule (PANAS; Watson, Clark, & Tellegen, 1988), which served as a delay task (see Pyszczynski, Greenberg, & Solomon, 1999).

After completing the PANAS, participants were presented with a fabricated legal brief (modeled after the materials used by Rosenblatt et al., 1989) concerning a prostitute under arrest and awaiting bail. The case brief included the criminal charge; the defendant's address, employment record, length of residency, and criminal record (i.e., a prostitution conviction 6 months earlier, no failures to appear in court); a note about the defendant's lack of established community ties; and a recommendation against releasing the defendant on her own recognizance. A copy of the citation that was ostensibly issued to the defendant was also included and contained basic arrest information.

After reading the materials, participants recorded the amount of bail they would assign the defendant. Given that most college students are relatively unfamiliar with the bond-setting process, we included a statement indicating that most bonds for similar offenses ranged from $0 to $999. In addition, participants completed the Prostitution Attitudes Scale (PAS; Rosenblatt et al., 1989), which consists of five items concerning prostitution (two

against prostitution and three favoring prostitution); ratings are made on Likert scales ranging from −3 (*strongly disagree*) to +3 (*strongly agree*). The two antiprostitution items were reverse-coded, and ratings for the five items were averaged to yield an overall prostitution attitude score, with higher scores reflecting more favorable attitudes toward prostitution. The scale showed acceptable internal consistency ($\alpha = .74$).

## Results

A multivariate analysis of variance (ANOVA) showed no main effect of gender and no interaction between gender and ethnicity on either PAS score or bail amount (both *p*s > .86). Therefore, gender is not discussed here.

The main analyses were 2 (condition: mortality salience vs. control) × 2 (ethnicity: European American vs. Asian American) multivariate ANOVAs on our dependent variables of interest: PAS score and amount of bail. Although the multivariate main effect of ethnicity on both measures was marginal (Wilks's $\lambda = .85$), $F(2, 37) = 3.13$, $p = .055$, the multivariate interaction between condition and ethnicity was significant (Wilks's $\lambda = .77$), $F(2, 37) = 5.31$, $p = .009$. Univariate ANOVAs performed on each dependent measure separately yielded a main effect of ethnicity. Asian Americans reported more negative attitudes toward prostitution ($M = -0.25$, $SD = 0.23$) than European Americans reported ($M = 0.46$, $SD = 0.22$), $F(1, 38) = 5.02$, $p = .031$. Asian Americans also posted marginally higher bail ($M = \$549.85$, $SD = \$65.83$) than European Americans did ($M = \$385.67$, $SD = \$63.51$), $F(1, 38) = 3.30$, $p = .077$. Ethnicity and condition had a significant interactive effect on PAS score, $F(1, 38) = 10.263$, $p = .003$ (see Fig. 1), and a marginally significant interactive effect on bail amount, $F(1, 38) = 3.036$, $p = .090$. Planned comparisons showed results consistent with existing TMT research: European Americans reported a significantly more negative attitude toward prostitution in the mortality-salience condition ($M = -0.0092$, $SD = 0.28$) than in the control condition ($M = 1.022$, $SD = 0.34$), $t(20) = 2.10$, $p = .048$, whereas Asian Americans showed the opposite effect (mortality-salience condition: $M = 0.21$, $SD = 0.31$; control condition: $M = -0.73$, $SD = 0.34$), $t(18) = 2.73$, $p = .013$). European Americans posted marginally higher bail in the mortality-salience condition ($M = \$488.46$, $SD = 81.24$) than in the control condition ($M = \$278.88$, $SD = 81.24$), $t(20) = 1.89$, $p = .072$. Asian Americans showed the reverse pattern (mortality-salience condition: $M = \$495.27$, $SD = 88.32$; control condition: $M = \$604.44$, $SD = 97.64$), but this effect was not significant, $t(18) < 1$, $p = .472$.

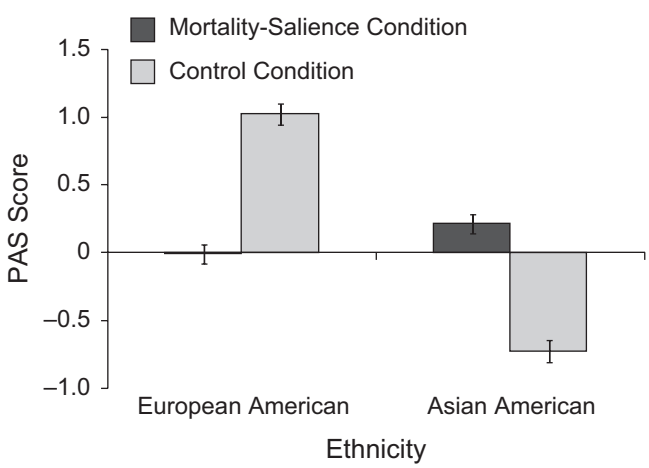


**Fig. 1.** Attitudes toward prostitution among European American and Asian American participants as a function of condition in Study 1. Attitudes were measured by the Prostitution Attitudes Scale (PAS; Rosenblatt, Greenberg, Solomon, Pyszczynski, & Lyon, 1989); higher scores reflect more positive attitudes toward prostitution. Error bars denote standard errors of the mean.

Additional planned comparisons revealed that European Americans and Asian Americans differed on PAS score in the control condition (mean difference = 1.75), $t(16) = 5.17$, $p < .001$, but not in the mortality-salience condition (mean difference = 0.22), $t(22) < 1$, $p = .53$. Likewise, European Americans differed from Asian Americans on the bail posted in the control condition (mean difference = \$325.65), $t(16) = 2.70$, $p = .015$, but not in the mortality-salience condition (mean difference = \$6.81), $t(22) < 1$, $p = .95$.

To address the possibility that mood drove the observed effects, we calculated net positive-mood scores using the PANAS (i.e., by subtracting the ratings given to the negative-mood items from the ratings given to the positive-mood items). Analyses of PAS scores and bail amounts revealed no main effects of mood or interactions involving mood (all *F*s <1).

## Discussion

Study 1 provided evidence that mortality salience causes culturally divergent responses, such that European Americans become more negative in their attitudes toward individuals who violate their worldviews, whereas Asian Americans become less negative in their attitudes toward such individuals. It is important to note that European Americans and Asian Americans in the control condition had disparate attitudes toward prostitutes (i.e., European Americans were more sympathetic toward prostitutes than were Asian Americans), so that the divergent pattern of responses of the two cultural groups actually led the groups to converge in their attitudes in the mortality-salience condition. This finding highlights the methodological importance of establishing baseline attitudes when comparing cultural groups.

We acknowledge that Study 1 had certain limitations. First, the nature of the dependent variables introduced a possible confound with political ideology. Given that Greenberg, Simon, Pyszczynski, Solomon, and Chatel (1992) found that liberals exhibited the same trend as the Asian Americans did in our study (i.e., they responded to mortality salience with increased tolerance), and that conservatives exhibited the same trend as the European Americans (i.e., they responded to mortality salience with decreased tolerance), it is possible that the observed cultural effects simply reflected a difference in political conservatism across cultures. However, given that

Asians tend to be more, not less, conservative than European Americans (Chia et al., 1994; Ross, 1997; Wang, 1998), this confound is unlikely.

Second, Study 1 was limited insofar as it measured responses to a highly nonnormative other person. However, past ethnographic research has demonstrated instances in which Asians have extended their collectivism to nonnormative individuals within their culture. Cultural anthropologists have argued, for example, that prostitutes are not necessarily condemned in traditional Chinese culture, given that a large number of rural women choose this type of work to support their family members (Robbins, 2008, p. 188). Likewise, many contemporary Japanese women view selling their bodies for sex, at least in certain contexts, as no different from other part-time jobs and as an acceptable form of capitalism (Moffett, 1995). In other words, although prostitution may be nonnormative insofar as it is not generally prescribed as a favorable manner of making one's living, it may nevertheless be tolerated under certain conditions (i.e., when other economic opportunities are lacking).

Furthermore, embracing nonnormative individuals can also serve to bolster the collective for Asian Americans insofar as it offers a way of integrating previously excluded members into the group, thereby expanding the in-group. Given that for the interdependent self, mortality salience poses a threat to the collective and the sustainability of social ties, bolstering the in-group through the integration of fringe members may alleviate the threat. Nevertheless, to answer the question of whether the same pattern would emerge with more normative targets, we conducted Study 2.

## Study 2

### Participants

Forty-eight European Americans (23 men and 25 women; mean age = 18.7 years) and 23 Asian Americans (11 men and 12 women of Chinese, Japanese, or Korean descent; mean age = 18.4 years) participated in Study 2. Of the 23 Asian Americans, 4 were first generation; the remaining participants were second generation.

### Measures and procedure

Participants completed the same manipulation used in Study 1, then the PANAS as a delay task, and finally an attribution task modeled after the one used by Hirschberger (2006). For the attribution task, they were handed a fabricated local-news article describing a serious car accident that left a university employee, "Steve," facing possible paralysis. The article made it clear that the employee was following all traffic rules and that the accident was not his fault. Participants were then given the Assignment of Blame Scale (ABS; Hirschberger, 2006), a four-item scale assessing their reaction to and attribution for the cause of the victim's state. Sample items include, "Steve is to blame for his condition" and "Steve could have done more to avoid his situation." Participants rated their agreement with each item on a scale from 1 (*strong disagreement*) to 7 (*strong agreement*). The scale exhibited acceptable internal consistency ($\alpha = .62$).

### Results

There was no main effect of gender on ABS score, nor were there any significant interactions involving gender (all $F$s < 1). Thus, gender is not discussed further.

A univariate ANOVA on the effects of ethnicity and condition on ABS score revealed a main effect of ethnicity, $F(1, 68) = 7.13$, $p = .009$. Asian Americans assigned higher blame to the victim ($M = 2.01$, $SD = 0.16$) than European Americans did ($M = 1.50$, $SD = 0.13$). However, this main effect was qualified by a significant interaction between ethnicity and condition, $F(1, 68) = 11.05$, $p = .001$ (see Fig. 2). Planned contrasts revealed results consistent with existing TMT research: European Americans in the mortality-salience condition blamed the victim more ($M = 1.68$, $SD = 0.14$) than did those in the control condition ($M = 1.31$, $SD = 0.15$), $t(46) = 2.119$, $p = .040$. However, Asian Americans in the mortality-salience condition blamed the victim less ($M = 1.55$, $SD = 0.29$) than did those in the control condition ($M = 2.48$, $SD = 0.19$), $t(22) = 2.15$, $p = .043$. Additional planned contrasts revealed that ABS scores differed significantly between European Americans and Asian Americans in the control condition (mean difference = 1.16), $t(34) = 4.65$, $p < .001$, but not in the mortality-salience condition (mean difference = 0.13), $t(33) < 1$, $p = .68$.

To once again address the alternative explanation that mood drove the observed effects, we calculated net positive-mood

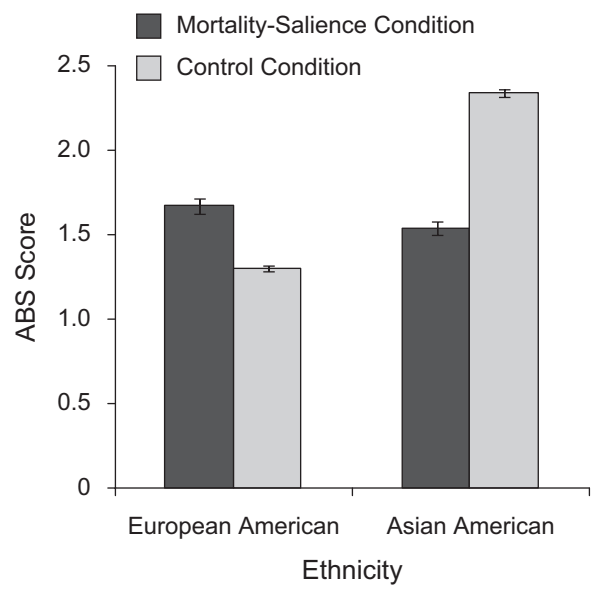


**Fig. 2.** Assignment of blame to the victim by European American and Asian American participants as a function of condition in Study 2. Blame was measured by the Assignment of Blame Scale (ABS; Hirschberger, 2006); higher scores reflect greater blame. Error bars denote standard errors of the mean.

scores from the PANAS. Analyses of ABS scores revealed no main effects of mood or interactions involving mood (all $F$s < 1).

### *Discussion*

Results from Study 2 provide further evidence that the pattern of responses of Asian Americans and European Americans diverged. European Americans blamed the victim more in the mortality-salience condition than in the no-threat (control) condition (presumably because they used blame to psychologically distance themselves from the victim), whereas Asian Americans blamed the victim less in the mortality-salience condition than in the no-threat condition. Rather than psychologically distancing themselves from the innocent victim, Asian Americans demonstrated increased psychological closeness to the victim after thinking death-related thoughts. Again, these divergent responses ultimately led the two groups to appear similar under mortality-salience conditions. Given that European Americans and Asian Americans in the control condition had different reactions to the victim, mortality salience caused cultural convergence by leading European Americans to increase their blame assignment and Asian Americans to lower their blame assignment; thus, the two groups differed in the control condition, but not in the mortality-salience condition.

## General Discussion

In these studies, death threat (i.e., mortality salience) caused cultural divergence in response patterns, but led to cultural convergence in actual attitudes. This cross-cultural similarity in outcome belies the divergent underlying processes: Death-related thoughts caused European Americans to defensively bolster the self (via derogation of dissimilar others) but caused Asian Americans to bolster other people. In Study 1, mortality salience produced increased derogation of a culturally nonnormative individual among European Americans, but decreased derogation of that individual among Asian Americans. Likewise, in Study 2, mortality salience led European Americans to blame an innocent victim more, but led Asian Americans to blame him less.[2]

One potential limitation of this work is the use of Asian Americans rather than Asians born and raised in Asia. Given past work demonstrating that bicultural individuals can activate different (cultural) selves in different situations (e.g., Greenberg et al., 1992), one alternative explanation for our findings is that mortality salience activated the more culturally dominant self (i.e., the Western self) among the Asian Americans. We offer two arguments against this possibility. First, many cultural-psychology studies have relied on bicultural individuals; past studies that have compared European Americans with both Asian Americans and Asians from Asia have typically found the latter two groups to be highly culturally similar to each other and culturally dissimilar to European Americans (e.g., Chentsova-Dutton & Tsai, 2010; Iyengar & Lepper, 1999; Kim & Sherman, 2007; Taylor et al., 2004; Taylor, Welch, Kim, & Sherman, 2007). Second, our findings showed that Asian Americans and European Americans responded to mortality salience in divergent ways, thereby casting strong doubt on the possibility that a Western self was activated for the bicultural individuals.

In sum, this research demonstrates both the universality of the terror management system—a system evolved to help humans cope with the awareness of their own mortality—and its cultural contingency. On the one hand, death is a universal problem—one that leads individuals to increase their adherence to their culturally prescribed worldviews. On the other hand, death-related thoughts produce very different responses among members of different cultures—though as our findings show, such disparities may appear to indicate cross-cultural similarity. It is important to note, however, that our findings of divergent processes are consistent with TMT's basic premise: When death is salient, people affirm the self. Although the manifestation of such self-striving is different across cultures (given differences between individualists' and collectivists' views of the nature of the self), the underlying goal is nevertheless the same.

Going beyond terror management, this work sheds light on the fact that although different processes may often be at work in different cultures, they may produce ironically similar results—a phenomenon that, up to this point, has received little attention in cultural psychology. Future work should more closely explore how, and when, different processes lead to similar outcomes among different cultural groups.

### Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The authors declared that they had no conflicts of interest with respect to their authorship or the publication of this article.

### Notes

1. Although interdependence/independence is only one aspect of culture, it is particularly relevant to TMT given that this dimension fundamentally concerns the self. At the core of TMT is the question of how individuals protect the self in the face of existential terror; cultural differences in how the self is construed should be particularly meaningful in this context.
2. It is important to note that in both studies, evaluations of the target did not implicate any evaluations of the in-group. The targets, though dissimilar to the participants (e.g., as a nonnormative other in Study 1 and an innocent victim facing paralysis in Study 2), were not directly oppositional to either cultural group's worldviews. Whether Asian Americans would demonstrate the same pattern under different conditions (e.g., in the presence of a target critical of their in-group) is a question for future research.

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